

Advanced Passive Voice

B2 · Upper-Intermediate · Passives with modals, the get-passive, and passive infinitives/gerunds.

You already know the basic passive. At B2, you'll extend it to work with modals, and meet a more informal alternative: the get-passive.

Rules

a) Passive with modals

modal + be + past participle.

- The report must be finished by Friday.
- This problem can be solved easily.
- The rules should be followed carefully.

b) Get-passive (informal)

get + past participle, common in spoken English, especially for accidents/unplanned events.

- My phone got stolen last week. (= was stolen, more informal/dynamic)
- She got promoted last month.

c) Passive infinitives and gerunds

- Passive infinitive: The house needs to be painted.
- Passive gerund: I don't like being told what to do.

Examples

- The report must be finished by Friday.
- This problem can be solved easily.
- My phone got stolen last week.
- She got promoted last month.
- The house needs to be painted.
- I don't like being told what to do.

Common Mistakes

× The report must finished by Friday.

✓ The report must be finished by Friday.

Modal + passive always needs "be" before the past participle.

✗ My phone got steal last week.

✓ My phone got stolen last week.

The get-passive needs the past participle (stolen), not the base form.

✗ The house needs to painted.

✓ The house needs to be painted.

A passive infinitive needs "to be," not just "to."

✗ I don't like told what to do.

✓ I don't like being told what to do.

A passive gerund needs "being" before the past participle.

Summary

- Modal passive: modal + be + past participle.
- Get-passive (informal): get + past participle, common for unplanned/personal events.
- Passive infinitive: to be + past participle. Passive gerund: being + past participle.

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